

crescent symbol in
post-490 BCE coins

owl, the sacred
bird of Athena

Athenian coin

The Athenian silver tetradrachm has an image of an owl on one side and a helmeted head on the other. It was also stamped with the Greek letters for "ATHE" to identify the city of its origin.

1200 BCE

Shells as money
Beginning from the Maldives, the use of cowrie shells as money spreads throughout the Pacific, and, by the 19th century, into Africa.



Cowrie shells

Prehistory

Cattle as capital

Prehistoric people use cattle as money, with animals such as sheep or chickens sometimes acting as small change.



Cattle

1000–500 BCE

Tool money

In China, common tools are cast in metal, punched with holes (for stringing several together), and used as money.



Knife money

c. 640–630 BCE

First true coins

The state of Lydia produces the first true coins, made of electrum (an alloy of gold and silver) and stamped with an image of a lion or stag.



Lydian coins

465–454 BCE

Greek coins

Almost every Greek city-state issues its own coinage, often with the name of the state inscribed on it. Silver replaces electrum as the main metal used.

27 BCE–14 CE

Augustan aureus

Emperor Augustus reforms the Roman coinage system and issues a new version of the standard gold coin, the aureus, worth 25 silver denarii.



Gold aureus